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Autonomy 1 — Hack and Learn

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Autonomy 1 — Hack and Learn

3 September · autonomy slot, 1h30 · nobody is in the room Serves: C1. Continues [Lab 1](#).

Two halves. The default split is **60 minutes hacking, 30 minutes learning** — a default, not a rule. If your units genuinely need the whole slot, spend the whole slot on them; the vocabulary half is short by design and survives being done on the train that evening.

Nothing here is handed in.

Hack (60 min) — finish the remaining units

Pick up where Lab 1 stopped. **Each remaining unit, in its own fresh context**: clear the session or open a new one, hand it one ticket and nothing else.

Every time a fresh session asks for something the ticket does not contain, **fix the ticket, not the prompt**. Then note what was missing. That list — what your tickets keep failing to say — is one of the most convincing things you can bring to the oral, because it is evidence you tested your own decomposition instead of describing it.

If the destination has moved since Friday, move it deliberately: delete the tickets you no longer believe in, edit the spec, cut new tickets from it. Keep the code already shipped unless it is in the way.

While you are in there: watch what actually gets sent

You are opening fresh contexts all the time anyway, so open one behind a proxy and look at it before you type anything.

[agent-proxy](#) is a small logging proxy that sits between the agent and the API and writes a Markdown report of exactly what was sent to the model on every turn — the system prompt, every tool schema, the whole message history, ranked by size.

```
# in one terminal, following the gist's setup
node agent-proxy.mjs
```

```
# in another, in your repository
ANTHROPIC_BASE_URL=http://localhost:8787 claude
```

Send one message. Open the report. Read the ranking, and look for **<tool-use>** and **<system-reminder>** while you are there.

The thing to notice: **most of what is sent is not your prompt**. That is what fills up, and that is what a compaction is compressing. Ten minutes, once, and "context" stops being an abstraction. It is not assessed.

Learn (30 min) — validate the vocabulary

Lecture 1 and Lab 1 used a lot of words quickly. This half is where you check which of them you actually own.

One flow, not two destinations. Start at the graph — <https://www.aicodingdictionary.com/> — and roam it. Open a term and you get a side panel: a short definition, **Heard in the wild**, **Avoid**, and **Connects to** chips, which are the graph's edges. Follow **Read full entry** through to the classic page at <https://www.aihero.dev/ai-coding-dictionary> whenever the panel is not enough.

Graph first, deliberately: it shows you which words sit next to which, and that adjacency is the thing a lecture cannot hand you.

The checklist — words you heard this week

You should be able to say each of these out loud, in your own words. A word you cannot is your reading for the slot; the rest you can skip.

- **The layers**: model, harness, agent, environment
- **What fills up**: token, context window, session, turn, stateless
- **Managing it**: smart zone, compaction, clearing, handoff, spec, ticket, primary vs secondary source
- **How it goes wrong**: sycophancy, hallucination, non-determinism
- **What it knows**: parametric vs contextual

Two things not to waste time looking for

- **unit of work, blocking edge, tracer bullet** and **hook** are ours or the wider industry's. They are not in the dictionary. Do not go looking.
- **smart zone, grilling** and **AX** — *agent experience*, the ergonomics a repository offers the agent working in it, the way DX is the ergonomics it offers a developer — are one shop's coinage. Useful here; in an interview elsewhere, explain them rather than drop them.

Why bother, given nothing is handed in

Two reasons, in this order:

1. **The oral is conducted in this vocabulary**, and you will be asked to name things. Six minutes is not long enough to talk around a word you half-know.
2. You are **invited, not required**, to drop the terms you had to look up into the notes in your own repository. It costs a line each, and it lands in the repository you already have to push — so it becomes C1 evidence you were going to produce anyway.

Credits

The dictionary is aihero.dev's (Matt Pocock); so is [agent-proxy](#).

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